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"'It's Growl You May, But go You Must': The Untapped Potential of the Sailor's Chantey"

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ABSTRACT
This article situates the chantey, sailing worksongs of the sea, within the field of Oceanic Studies and ventures the argument that chanteys should be viewed as maritime artifacts that will evolve interdisciplinary research dealing with the sea and sailing men. I begin by addressing the primary reasons that scholars have likely not performed close readings of collected texts and take time to point to the issues inherent in working with this genre, but then move to discuss the importance of engaging in such inquiries. The primary contention is that chanteys provide a further way by which scholars can investigate the life of the sailor and succeed in "acknowledging the sailor", as Emily Cuming notes (2019), in ways that layer our understanding of his experience at sea and participate in viewing maritime history, as Marcus Rediker (2015) suggests, from the other end of the spyglass.

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To bend to one's task, as insurmountable or ill-advised as it may seem, is and was the lot of the sailor. To admit, as informant Stanton King does in his plaintive version of "Leave Her, Johnny, Leave Her", "growl you may, but go you must" is to recognise dually that you can complain and gnash your teeth, mutter under your breath, but you have to push through, keep going, and complete what is ahead of you.[1] The work is important because, at least on the sailing ship, it is the difference between life and death, getting the ship home or stagnating on the open water. The sailor's work was gruelling and dangerous, sometimes life-altering, but he knew that he had no other choice but to keep his head bent and his back braced. Growling happened, of course, and the sailor's protestations found their way into spaces like the collective action found in Round Robins, open insurrection, clashes with those in power, or even in his work songs of the sea.[2] These work songs, called *chanteys*, are indeed important cultural

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[1]James Madison Carpenter, The James Madison Carpenter Collection. Vaughn Williams Memorial Library. Reference: VWMLSongIndex/SN25118, JMC/1/1/4/B, 1928. Stan Hugill, in *Shanties from the Seven Seas*, provides a version of "Bunch O' Roses," that employs a similar plaintive cry. Hugill notes that the song, though "It was fairly popular in Liverpool ships" is "overlooked by most collectors," and goes on to provide a version of the song from William Main Doerflinger "from the MS of Nathaniel Silsbee, of Cohasset, Mass" (274, 275). He claims that the song was "popular too in Yankee ships" (274). The lyric " 'Tis growl ye may but go on ye must/If ye growl too hard yer head they'll bust" is given as the sixth stanza (276). Hugill also notes that the song was sung as a part of "the film *Moby Dick*" (275).

[2]See Jones, "Space, sound and sedition on the Royal Naval ship, 1756–1815," for a fascinating discussion of "sonic protests," investigating such elements of sound on ship as murmurs and mutters, humming, and even nighttime disturbances.

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artifacts through which we can glance at the life and lot of the sailor. Like the whaler's scrimshaw or Naval sailing man's memoir, the chantey is a valuable relic of the forecastle for what it might tell us about the sailing man and his life. More importantly than other small pieces of the sailing man's habits, keepsakes, or folkways, the chantey functioned in multiple and purposeful ways that render it a powerful item for scholars to investigate, not the least of which was that it served as a release valve for the frustrations of sailing life.

The *growling* or primary barrier toward moving chantey research forward is based on the complex nature of collected chanteys, especially in terms of locating stable examples with which to work.[3] It is an impromptu genre, with songs sung differently based on the chanteyman, the ship, the voyage, the men, and any number of situations that might befall a crew at any given time.[4] Now that the collecting and collating of early chanteys is long complete, I contend that the important work ahead of scholars, the *going on*, is the close reading and critical analysis of the texts that we have at our disposal which have been collected directly from sailing men. Folklore scholar Archie Green, in fact, suggests that "analysis must parallel collection", yet that type of close reading and analysis did not occur as chanteys were being recorded by early collectors like James Madison Carpenter, Robert Winslow Gordon, and others.[5] Indeed, early collection potentially obscured the tradition and contributed to a cultural relationship with chanteys that we are still working to disentangle today.[6]

This article will venture a two-masted approach: addressing both the growling suggested above, but also the *going on*. I will begin by unpacking where scholarship is with the genre at the moment. The barriers toward the path of the more rewarding work of analysis, and what has prevented more inquiry into chanteys as objects for analysis, are that collected chanteys need to be contextualised, often require sometimes impossible authentication, and are in need of critical conceptualisation. Some of this work has already begun through the research and critical discussion of ethnomusicologist Gibb Schreffler (2018); however, here, the task is to introduce the chantey in terms of what they were (and are), how they were attached to work and bodies, what critical elements of the genre need to be understood, and what is left to do, critically, in terms of collected examples in archival and published form.[7] Erotic folklore and folksong collector Gershon Legman, incidentally a collector who culled bawdy examples of chanteys from the famed singer and collector Stan Hugill, outlines that "the job of American folksong specialists, as in England and the rest of Europe long since, has now moved on to something more difficult: that the shotgun collecting phase [of folksong] has now to give way, and the indexing and actual study have got to begin".[8] It is this enduring call that I contend is the "moving on", the path forward in the study of

[3]Marcus Rediker specifically points to songs as being key to understanding facets of the sailor's life, but also remarks that the process is rendered difficult by the complexities inherent in working with the genre. See note 103, page, 189 in *Between the Devil and the Deep Blue Sea*."

[4]See Bullen, *Songs of Sea Labor*, vi. Bullen notes that chanteys were impromptu to the degree that he refused to publish more than the beginning lines of a sing-out. Sailors then extemporized the remaining stanzas as they worked.

[5]Green, "American Labor Lore".

[6]See Schreffler *Boxing the Compass* for an extensive cataloguing of collections and how each epoch contributed to shaping a relationship with the genre that was largely tied to cultural desires or to a collector's particular motivations rather than accurate presentations of the genre as sailing men conceived of it.

[7]Schreffler *Boxing the Compass*.

[8]Legman, "Misconceptions in Erotic Folklore".

this rich cultural tradition, pushing past the barrier of unstable collected examples toward the rich insights these objects promise, especially concerning the working-class men who shaped them.

What is a Chantey and Why is Authentication Important?

A *chantey*, very simply, is a sailing work song of the sea that coordinated the work of sailing ships and was considered a tool in the sailors' arsenal, not unlike other tools of the trade like rope and tar.[9] Frederick Pease Harlow, in his *Chanteying Aboard American Ships* opines that "Sailors were so accustomed to singing out when there was a pull to be made, that I have actually heard an old sailor give a 'Yo-ho-hip' when pulling on his sea boots".[10] When I use the term *chantey* I am specifically denoting a specific genre that was a part of the sailing man's work at sea. Songs created in the "spirit of chanteys" or songs that were actually popular culture imaginings of the sailing man are not the object of focus here such as can be found in sea songs and ballads which are often miscategorised as chanteys and usually under the catchall term *shanty*.[11] Chanteys were so tied to the sailor's vocation that types of chanteys are denoted based on the jobs for which they were employed.[12] For brevity, there were hauling and heaving songs; however, there are some scholars and collectors who specifically type songs using their shipboard applications such as windlass, capstan, halyard, short haul, sweating up, bunt, hand-over-hand, stamp-'n'go, and pump chanteys.[13] The chanteyman, a man on ship prized for his voice and ability to extemporise, would begin the song with a sing-out and fellow sailors would bend to their task as they belted out the refrain.[14] The tie to work cannot be overstated; for, as the refrain is sung, the sailor's bodies were engaged in the particular task at hand. For instance, in a capstan or heaving song like "Blow the Man Down", the longer, ballad-like tune would permit collective effort as sailors steadily walked around the capstan. Chanteys were texts that organised bodies, akin to what Dorothy Smith highlights in her "Texts and the Ontology of Organizations".[15] The chanteys, in a way, function as the texts that formulate a process: the process of collective work.[16] In the process of these texts ordering a collectivity, Michel Foucault's theory of institutions ordering bodies into what he terms *docile bodies* highlights what disciplined bodies do and become.[17] Bodies, as they are employed in collective singing and maritime work, become united breath, body, voice, and action and even aligned with a new identity.

[9]For an extensive discussion of the term and its application, see Schreffler, " 'The Execrable Term'"
[10]Harlow, *Chanteying Aboard American Ships*, 7. The ties to work, in particular, may stem from the conjectured African-American origin of chanteys, which will be discussed further in Chapter II.
[11]For examples of songs that appear like chanteys, but which are actually sea songs or sea ballads, see Didbin, *The Sea Songs of Charles Didbin*.
[12]Schreffler does note, however, that this reading could be a bias attached to chanteys based on White singers and collectors. See *Boxing the Compass* 98–99.
[13]For the full list of possible chantey types, see Hugill, *Shanties from the Seven Seas*, 26.
[14]Hugill provides an illustrative description of the process involved with sing-outs, as well as the impromptu nature of chanteys, in *Shanties from the Seven Seas*, 30–33.
[15]Smith, "Texts and the Ontology of Organizations and Institutions". See also Michel Foucault's discussion of *docile bodies*, to be discussed below, in *Discipline & Punish*, 135–69.
[16]See Hugill, *Shanties from the Seven Seas*, 31.
[17]Foucault, *Discipline & Punish*, 149.

To the latter point, the songs were a key component to work, but they also facilitated bonds among men, sometimes from disparate places, functioning to solidify a brotherhood of the forecastle. Mary K. Bercaw Edwards writes of the connection among sailor talk, song, and the importance of comradery on ship when she writes

> Sailor talk has a social importance as well as a physical importance. Nautical terminology is important for keeping the sailors alive – the breath in their bodies, the wind in their sails – but occupational lore and coterie speech keep their social groups working.[18]

Chanteys were a part of the occupational lore and even coterie speech, containing within them narratives of sailing life, expressions of longing for home and hearth, and even potentially served as *hidden transcripts* to critique the tyranny of sailing life like the cry that opened this inquiry.[19] Folksong, like the sailor's chantey, should be viewed as a folklore item rooted in the spirit of collectivity similar to what has been identified in other homosocial spaces like freemasonry, branches of the military, and even modern fraternities. The sailing ship on which chanteys were sung was not unlike what has been identified as "fratriarchies" which Ben Wadham notes function through " 'rule of the brother – [hoods]'" where items like song generate comradery and an air of difference between themselves and those not a part of the homosocial space.[20] Humorous, irreverent, and bawdy as they sometimes are, which will be apparent in examples below, chanteys are complicated artifacts that often betray far deeper human realities that attended not only the sailors who sang them, but potentially connect to other communities of working-class men and women who used and use song as a bonding mechanism and as a way to generate strength and perseverance together like military cadences, lumberjack songs, and even Scottish Waulking Songs.

Knowing what chanteys are and how they functioned on ship is at least one part of understanding the genre. The second layer, however, is contending with the challenge presented by the mire of competing arguments and complications concerning authentic chantey texts. In terms of the chantey's origin, some contend they originated in Early America, as a part of African American work songs.[21] Locating a chantey in a specific place of origin can contribute to more illustrative readings of the content; for example, situating "The Hog Eye Man" as a chantey that began as an African American work song, scholars have firmer ground on which to consider the content based on its

[18]Edwards, *Sailor Talk*, 250.

[19]See Scott, *Domination and the Arts of Resistance*.

[20]Wadham, "Brotherhood". The comparison between the sailing ship and other homosocial environments is a project unto itself; however, some works to consult would be Morrison, "Making Degenerates into Men by Doing Shots"; Eastman, Danaher, and Schrock, "Gendering Truck Driving Songs: "; Oberweis, Petrocelli, and Foster, "Walking the Walk and Talking the Talk". See also Bailey, "Brave Shanty Boys. Noteworthy is that in homosocial song literature, there is a distinctive "us vs. them" which generates a clear demarcation between the singers and noted "others," often women.

[21]The arguments concerning who first sung chanteys would be an investigation in and of itself. For reference points, Isaac Allen, one of the first to write about chanteys in his 1858 Oberlin College paper notes that the songs he heard sounded similar to African-American work songs (Oberlin Students' Monthly, Vol. I, Shankland and Harmon: 1858, 48. R. W. Gordon, in "Folk Songs of America: Work Chanteys," *The New York Times*, 16 January 1927, argues that "With the sailor chanteys [sic] he did the same thing. The negro on the docks heard them sung by white sailors. He borrowed them with minor variations. Those he liked he rebuilt to suit better his own tasks, and later he invented new chanties [sic] on the old model" (22). William Main Doerflinger claimed that chanteys were entirely different from African American work songs in *Songs of the Sailor and the Lumberman* (Illinois: Meyerbooks, 1951), 7. Schreffler contends "that while forecastle songs were British, chanties were American" in "Twentieth-Century Editors and the Re-envisioning of Chanties: A Case Study of 'Lowlands,'" *The Nautilus V*, (2014), 14. See also the introduction to Elijah Wald's, *Jelly Roll Blues: Censored Songs & Hidden Histories* (New York: Hachette Book Group, 2024).

connection to a specific period and tradition.[22] There is yet another contention that situates chanteys firmly in the UK.[23] Some argue for chanteys originating and remaining in what was once the West Indies; indeed, Stan Hugill, the self-proclaimed last chantey man, draws attention to the reality that most of his chanteys were learned from West Indian sailing men.[24] There are also complications with dating and situating versions within finite periods of time for more careful analysis. There is an argument to be made that chanteys are purely a nineteenth-century phenomenon that was tied to the rise of folklore and folksong collection more broadly.[25] Others contend that it is much older and that it can be traced back the 1400s where proto-chanteys have been observed as hitches and yells tied to work.[26] Schreffler specifically traces the songs to the creation of a specific windlass and capstan in the 1800s.[27] Paul Gilje connects chantey narratives to the ballad tradition in his discussion of maritime culture, placing songs in the eighteenth century noting that "although all of this music had pre-1815 antecedents, shanties, reminiscent of some earlier ballads, often were bawdy and spoke more directly to the hard life of the mariner at sea and on land".[28] It is, perhaps, more advantageous to consider a more expansive and purely maritime cosmopolitan origin, placing chanteys in no one place, but being specifically wed to a maritime identity across the oceans and the period 1400–1890.

The lyrics of chanteys and what constitutes an authentic song for research and discussion is also the subject of debate. There are contentions that chanteys are only authentic when they were collected as the beginning lines or sing-outs.[29] The fact remains, though, that fixed chantey lyrics are extant and worthy of deeper investigation. At the very least, these fixed versions are representative of one singer's repertoire and provide a finite text to investigate not unlike what is encountered in ballad research.[30] Collected texts also demonstrate that there are bawdy versions of songs, but more often they are clean.[31]

[22]Gershon Legman, Unpublished Manuscript: Gershon Legman Collection. Kinsey Institute. "Hog-Eye Man" note (pejorative language here is a mark of the period and also the two men who collected the song material): "Hugill notes: 'This links this shanty with the white and coloured stevedore or hoosiers (cotton stowers of Mobile and New Orleans, from whom many shanties stemmed."

[23]Gerry Smyth, in his "Shanty Singing and the Irish Atlantic: Identity and Hybritity in the Musical Imagination of Stan Hugill," makes a compelling argument concerning the Irish origin of some sea chanteys. He also contends that "The shanty might be regarded as a typical product of the diasporic imagination—a riposte to the powerful conceptual framework which maintains 'a homology between a culture, a people, or a nation and its particular terrain" (*International Journal of Maritime History* 29, no. 2 (2017): 387–406, 400).

[24]Abrahams, *Deep the Water, Shallow the Shore* discuss the African American, African, and West Indian origin of chanteys and their continued use. See the prefaces for the 1974 publication and 2002 (Mystic: Mystic Seaport Museum, 2002). Hugill, *Shanties from the Seven Seas*, covers the many arguments of origin from page 7–20.

[25]See McDowell, *The Invention of the Oral*, 34 where she notes "in the nineteenth century, oral tradition became a research program. Traditions once castigated as superstitious 'rubbish' were now venerated as 'folklore'—a term coined in 1846" and also page 231 where she indicates that "later eighteenth- and nineteenth-century ballad scholars increasingly modeled a distinct 'oral tradition' or balladry that was threatened or displaced by commercial print, and they represented themselves as working to 'rescue' this tradition before it was too late."

[26]For earlier dating, see the argument made by Broadwood and Fox-Strangways, "Early Chanty-Singing and Ship-Music".

[27]Gibb Schreffler has tied the chantey to a very specific period, tying the emergence of the chantey with the creation of a new lever windlass in his presentation for the Music of the Sea Symposium, Mystic, CT, June 2015. The title of his paper was "Rethinking the Practical Use of Chanties; or, Why the Charles W. Morgan's Windlass is a Priceless Item of Historical Significance."

[28]Gilje, *To Swear Like a Sailor*, 170.

[29]See Bullen, *Songs of Sea Labour*, vi and also Terry, *Sailing Ship Shanties*, 7.

[30]See Mary Ellen Brown, "Placed, replaced, or misplaced? The ballads' progress," *Eighteenth Century* 47 (2006) 2/3: 115–129, 127.

[31]W. B. Whall, *Sea Songs and Shanties*, xiii notes that "Now seamen who spent their time in cargo-carrying sailing ships never heard a *decent* shanty."

Unfortunately, the researcher is often met with the reality that whole song lyrics were changed or deleted in printed and published collections so as to pass strict censorship laws.[32] Indeed, Legman castigates scholarly collectors in his *The Horn Book* and scathingly writes "It may be shortly said that the entire history of folksong publication in the English language is one of falsification and expurgation for the last two hundred years, and that it has invariably disguised forgeries and dishonesties behind mealy-mouthed prefatory brags of sexual purity".[33] In addition to complications with chantey lyrics, the genre often appears saturated with capstan and windlass chanteys as these were privileged during the height of collection as they were akin not only to folksong performance pieces that were popular, but they were also similar to the ballads that early folklorists were actively collecting when such pursuits began.[34] Scholars also must contend with the evolution of the chantey from the genre that was collected directly from the mouths of sailors, in the nineteenth century, and the imagined renditions of chantey tunes that began during folklore revivals and culminates in the viral TikTok sensation a global culture experienced during the height of the COVID19 pandemic.[35] In this latter complication, researchers must contend with the conflation of this working class song tradition with popular culture imaginings of the sailor which bias the caricature of the rabblerousing sailor and lean into a reading of chanteys as akin to drinking songs and general revelry.[36] Valerie Burton has extensively critiqued this representation of the sailor, but it persists and is even aggrandised by "the anachronistic adopting of chanty [*sic*] repertoire by 'pyrate' interpreters and Elizabethan players at Renaissance Faires", not to mention other popular culture content like the video game *Assassin's Creed IV: Black Flag*, which conflates chanteys with pirates erroneously.[37]

Similar to Schreffler, Kelby Rose draws attention to "modern popular culture, [and how] shanties are frequently performed romantically at renaissance and maritime festivals or adapted and blended into songs performed by pirate-rock groups".[38] The chantey

[32]An example of Hugill's notes on songs, from *Shanties from the Seven Seas*, can be found in the notes concerning the "milkmaid version of "Blow the Man Down" where he writes that it "is distinctly Rabelaisian and [lyrics] had to be camouflaged quite a lot" (165).

[33]Legman, *The Horn Book*, 342.

[34]Schreffler, Boxing the Compass, 51 and 86.

[35]For an example of this, see "Sea Shanty Crew boozy seaside sing-along during stunning sunset at RNLI station," by Lucinda Herbert for *The Shields Gazette*, 16 June 2025 https://www.shieldsgazette.com/watch-this/shanty-crews-boozy-seaside-sing-along-for-rnli-during-stunning-sunset-5178121 or Daniel J. Willis, "Rewind: The youths like sea shanties, so let's hear some modern shanties," for Riff Magazine 16 January 2021 https://riffmagazine.com/tuesday-tracks/rewind-20210116-modern-sea-shanties/ In the latter, the author conflates some contemporary metal songs with chanteys, though the metal songs were completely created by the bands themselves and not chanteys at all. "Sea shanty" is also redundant. Consider also "pirate singers" at Renaissance Festivals and "chanteys" sung in pubs or as a part of "chantey" bands. For the latter, see Schreffler, *Boxing the Compass*, 99.

[36]For a representation of a song collection that conflates irreverent material of all kinds, without proper categorization, see the anonymous collection *Immortalia: An Anthology of American Ballads, Sailors' Songs, Cowboy Songs, College Songs, Parodies, Limericks, and other Humorous Verses and Doggerel Now for the First Time Brought Together in Book Form: By a Gentleman About Town*, 1927. Gershon Legman critiques this collection in his 1964 *The Horn Book: Studies in Erotic Folklore and Bibliography*, New York: University Books, p. 397. See also Richard Docker's 2004 *Salty Dick's Uncensored Sailor Songs*. Songs like "Friggin' in the Riggin'" and others are included, though this song is a sea song and not a chantey. Gershon Legman critiques collections like Immortalia, though, in his 1964 *The Horn Book: Studies in Erotic Folklore and Bibliography*, (New York: University Books), 397.

[37]First, see Burton '"As I wuz a-Rolling Down the Highway One Morn", 141–56, 144. Schreffler discusses popular culture renditions of chanteys as they are attached to imagined origins, specifically White and British, *Boxing the Compass*, 99. An argument can be made that the conflation of chanteys with pirates can be traced to Robert Louis Stevenson's *Treasure Island* and the song "Fifteen Men on a Dead Man's Chest."

[38]Rose, "Nostalgia and Imagination in Nineteenth-Century Sea Shanties".

scholar is in a unique and complicated position where it is necessary to disentangle the authentic chantey from the popular culture imaginings of it. Such authentication is, perhaps, more important at this moment with the revival of chantey singing. As Schreffler notes that "recognition of the perspectives that inform current chanty-singing [*sic*], its presentation, and it auxiliary discourse helps us to distinguish these from those we may find in texts from the nineteenth century".[39] Songs sung as a part of the viral TikTok sensation are akin to the songs that were collected and sung as a part of folksong rivals in the 1960s and 1970s where song content was packaged, sold, and circulated to consuming audiences to the detriment of the oral traditional materials and the sailors who sang them. Schreffler importantly draws attention to the reality that many collected and published "chantey" collections were shaped and circulated for performance, distinctly impacting "how twentieth-century audiences would envision the genre as a whole".[40] Songs that were about the sea and sailors often get classified as chanteys when the reality is that they were likely never sung as work songs of the sea. For instance, a song like "The Good Ship Venus", one version of which is located in Ed Cray's *Erotic Muse*, might be misrepresented as a chantey; for, it contains similarities to capstan songs based on its length, the fact that it is attached to sailors and sailing men in content, and contains within it the humour and levity we have grown to expect in something like an all-male bonding or work song.[41] The song is actually a forecastle song, which is the same miscategorisation that has occurred in popular culture spaces like TikTok and the viral sensation of "The Wellerman", which is actually a sea song and not a chantey at all, despite the many hashtags that attempt to collect the song under the catchall title of *shanty*.

Though, admittedly, collected songs demonstrate that almost anything could be made into a chantey and sailors often borrowed and changed content in order to fit the needs of a particular job on the ship, scholars of the genre must take time to disentangle songs sung by sailing men when at work as opposed to those songs that are circulated, more often, as shore songs and ballads.[42] Taking the time to situate and authenticate chanteys is an important process if a scholar is going to make any claims concerning the material discussed and if we are going to begin the work of defining the genre and rectifying inaccuracies. Rose, in "Nostalgia and Imagination in Nineteenth-Century Sea Shanties" provides one of the first analyses of collections of chantey texts for what they might represent about the interior lives of the sailors who sung them, but the text is representative of the importance of authenticating and situating the texts in order to make claims about what they articulate.[43] Rose investigates versions of songs published as a part of hard bound collections like those from Stan Hugill, Joanna Colcord, William Main Doerflinger,

[39]Schreffler, *Boxing the Compass*, 100.
[40]Ibid., 49.
[41]Cray, *The Erotic Muse*, 315.
[42]For an example of this cross-influence, see research dealing with the song "Barnacle Bill the Sailor," a tune often miscategorised as a chantey though it originated as a shore song. The song has been collected as a part of some chantey repertoires, demonstrating that there was some borrowing from shore songs to generate chantey material. See R. M. Davids "Abram Brown the Sailor" 1924 in R. W. Gordon's *Inferno Collection*, as well as "Bocardy Bill the Sailor," anonymous p. 389, "Bolakee Bill the Sailor," anonymous p. 480, among several others. The collection is housed in the Library of Congress, though several digitised copies exist in The Internet Archives, https://archive.org/details/1917gordoninfernocollection/page/n87/mode/2up, as well as the Jack Horntip Collection, https://www.horntip.com/html/books_&_MSS/1910s/1917-1933_gordon_inferno_collection_(MSS)/index.htm.
[43]Rose, "Nostalgia and Imagination in Nineteenth-Century Sea Shanties," 147.

Frederick Pease Harlow, and several others roundly critiqued in Schreffler's *Boxing the Compass* for being collections that were "a combination of both a compilation and original field collection".[44] Too, these publications are largely expurgated, often include sea songs and sea ballads re-packaged as chanteys, and often build on other publications of chantey texts without critically investigating them.[45] It is difficult to say if these chanteys truly represent a sailor's nostalgia or interiorities, or of the sensations identified in the songs are more distinctly tied to the collators who collected and published the collections.

In making claims about narratives of chanteys, it behooves the researcher to trace, as much as possible, the origin of the song under consideration, tracking to the degree one is able the year of collection, the singer, the places the sailor hailed, and even comparison to similar songs and narrative structures that might generate approximate historical information. Historian Valerie Burton notes that "sailortown songs and tales" are "problematic [artifacts]" and scholars should be mindful about situating such ephemera within the specific cultural milieu in which they were consumed and circulated.[46] Burton's observation is akin to Charles Joyner's concerning the use of folklore artifacts more generally. He notes that "historical context is no mere ornamentation to folkloristic inquiry, it is of its essence".[47] With collected examples of chanteys from the nineteenth-century, this process of authentication is not only more attainable, but focusing on these collections provides a foundation through which scholars can then begin the process of investigating later renditions of chanteys and what they have contributed to the overarching view of the genre.

Without attempting to authenticate or draw attention to the origin of materials under consideration, the scholar runs of the risk of circulating inaccurate information regarding the chantey and perpetuating the same miscategorizations that have taken place across decades of chantey research. In discussing Hugill's collection of chanteys, Schreffler notes that "Songs that were better known as forebitters or entertainment songs of the sea and shore, by dint of some occurrence of being sung at the pumps or capstan, became 'shanties' within the context of Hugill's work".[48] A similar recognition of mixed content has been identified in other oral traditional contexts, like ballad research, but here the importance becomes locating authentic work songs of the sea in order to rectify inaccurate depictions of the genre in popular culture and print arenas alike while also moving onto delving deeply into these collected examples for what they might articulate about the lives of sailing men.[49] To the degree possible, collectors like Gershon Legman, James Madison Carpenter, Robert Winslow Gordon, and Cecil Sharp, among others, actively worked to authenticate collected texts and position them for later study. Many of these collectors, arriving as a part of the emergent field of folklore studies, where "academic folkorists [who] recorded the musical and lyrical peculiarities of specific singers; they were relatively methodical and descriptive, as opposed to the 'generic', quasi-composite versions of chanties that had previously been the norm".[50]

[44]Schreffler, *Boxing the Compass*, 26.
[45]Hugill's version of "Bunch O' Roses" demonstrates the process of collectors pulling from other published collections for their own chantey anthologies (274).
[46]Burton, " 'Whoring, Drinking Sailors'" 89.
[47]Joyner, "A Model for the Analysis of Folklore Performance in Historical Context".
[48]Schreffler, *Boxing the Compass*, 35.
[49]Dugaw, "On the 'darling Songs' of Poets, Scholars, and Singers".
[50]Schreffler, *Boxing the Compass*, 50.

The James Madison Carpenter Collection and R. W. Gordon's Inferno Collection, both now digitised, are each examples of archival chantey material where song content was taken directly from sailing informants, sometimes with their melodious voices recorded and, in each collection, are often accompanied by explanatory notes. These notations contextualise the collected song or even express more about the sailing man and his life before the mast. In *moving on*, the suggestion here is that scholars working in the field both recognise the importance of authentication, to the degree possible, while also recognising the difficulty inherent in that process. Authentication can never be a rigid process, as chanteys themselves were impromptu and porous, but beginning research into collected examples taken directly from sailors will prove fruitful for both what they might articulate of the sailor's life and also for the foundation they will generate that leads to inquiry into later iterations of the sailor's song, sometimes with the sailor wholly removed from the production of the content.

The Chantey's Voice in Oceanic Studies

Hester Blum suggests that scholars must be "attentive to the material conditions and praxis of the maritime world, one that draws from the epistemological structures provided by the lives and writings of those for whom the sea was simultaneously workplace, home, passage, penitentiary, and promise".[51] The chantey is one such cultural artifact that holds within it the *conditions* of the sea and sailing life, the *praxis* of the sailor, and even suggests some of the material cultural realities of the floating workplace in a new and provocative way. The "moving on" portion of this article situates the chantey within the field of Oceanic Studies and contends that scholars must focus on "Acknowledging the sailor" as doing this "allows us to perceive, analyze, and deploy aspects of the history, literature, and culture of the oceanic world that might otherwise be rendered obscure or abstract".[52] Chanteys serve as one component of the larger narrative of sailing lives and assist in filling in gaps in knowledge around the materiality and potential embodied personhood of the men who were a part of larger maritime history. Emily Cuming's work demonstrates the powerful promise that Oceanic studies makes, in that scholars are able to fully acknowledge the sailor and his life by leveraging often forgotten aspects of his everyday existence. Similar to what I propose here, we must begin to turn attention to sailing ephemera, like the chantey or what Cuming calls *nautical ornamental culture*, in order to continue building our understanding of the sea and sailing life in more nuanced and creative ways. What I am contending is that chanteys might serve as the shout over the din of the ocean noted in "The Prospect of Oceanic Studies" where "Oceanic studies could be more invested in the face of the sea's abyss of representation".[53] Almost every facet of the sailor's life was oral. His song, his storytelling, the way in which he transmitted knowledge of the craft, and even his specialised language were each oral traditional materials that speak to the sailor's identity.[54] Investigating the chantey would mean culling from that "abyss of representation", investing time and energy to what could, if we are not mindful, be swallowed up and lost in the sea of maritime inquiry,

[51]Blum, "The Prospect of Oceanic Studies".
[52]Cuming, "At Home in the World?.
[53]Blum, "The Prospect of Oceanic Studies," 670.
[54]Edwards, *Sailor Talk*, 66.

if only because too many have decided that the instability of the genre is unnavigable and therefore too hazardous an enterprise. The common sailor would, no doubt, laugh in the face of such fear.[55]

In the foreword to Richard Runciman Terry's *The Way of the Ship: Sailors, Shanties and Shantymen*, sailor Walter Runciman says that

> In speech, the old-time 'shellback' was notoriously reticent—almost inarticulate; but in song he found self-expression, and all the romance and poetry of the sea are breathed into his shanties, where simply childlike sentimentality alternates with the Rabelaisian humour of the grown man.[56]

The chanty is a tool of sailing work, salt-soaked and Rabelasian, but it is also a form of *self-expression* that contains incredible *romance and poetry*. Edwards notes, in discussing maritime music in nautical fiction, "Sea music, then, is a bridge to a richer understanding of London's maritime works", and I am contending that the sailor's chantey is yet another salient artifact that generates a bridge to understanding other aspects of the sailing man and his life through looking at one artifact of his sailing vocation that has been described, by a sailor and collector himself, to be both a product of the water and the sailor, but also a relic of a certain sailing identity, as long as the researcher is able to tie the song to the sailor himself with some degree of confidence.[57] We have yet to think more deeply about the intimate connection between and among the sailor's work song and other maritime materials that the sailor made or which were about the sailor. Turning attention to nautical ornamental culture continues the process of building a narrative of sailing lives that shapes a more nuanced image of the maritime world across time, space, and place.[58]

To date, scholars have attempted to build an image of the sailing man through a number of other cultural artifacts from the sea and sailing life. As discussed, Cuming has looked to sailing artifacts like scrimshaw and even what the sailor brought back with him from his travels to provide a new image of the sailor as a cosmopolitan and artful traveller. Additionally, researchers have access to sailing journals and memoirs that sailing men shaped either as they sailed before the mast or long after their tenure at sea.[59] These materials are obviously traceable to a singular man, during a particular period of time, and offer a wealth of information concerning the day-to-day lives of sailors who shipped out on various types of vessels in the time covered. Ashley Bowen's memoir (1728–1813) is one example of this type of first-person content, as is the incredible journal of Naval drummer Philip C. Van Buskirk.[60] Scholars have also

[55]Dana, in his *Two Years Before the Mast*, discusses the dark nature of sailing humor often. One example reads "Whatever your feelings may be, you must make a joke of everything at sea; and if you were to fall from aloft and be caught in the belly of a sail, and thus saved from instant death, it would not do to look at all disturbed, or to make a serious matter of it," 46.

[56]Terry, Foreword, *The Way of the Ship*.

[57]Edwards, " 'heartening the Weaklings'.

[58]Rouleau, "Dead Men Do Tell Tales" "; Rose "Nostalgia and Imagination in Nineteenth-century Sea Shanties" have each begun closer readings of chantey examples, albeit based on published collections that are open to critique.

[59]Though sailing memoirs are scattered, much like archival chantey texts, Naval History and Heritage Command provides a list of institutions that provide "significant collections" of maritime content for research. See https://www.history.navy.mil/research/library/research-guides/maritime-research-selected-institutions-with-significant-collections.html

[60]See Bowen, *The Autobiography of Ashley Bowen*; Buskirk, *Journal of a Cruize* now digitized as a part of CUNY Academic Commons, https://vanbuskirk.commons.gc.cuny.edu/the-diary-of-philip-c-van-buskirk/ See also Burg's, *An American Seafarer in the Age of Sail*.

investigated ships′ and surgeons′ logs, as B.R Burg and Seth LeJacq have, for what they might communicate about sailing men′s ages, home countries, and ailments, not to mention the garish medical interventions used to treat the hellacious wounds and maladies suffered during the course of a voyage.[61] Burg and Lejacq have each helped to generate a new history concerning the sexual lives of sailing men on naval sailing vessels, answering many enduring questions about the sailor′s penchant for erotic release that has been the subject of much speculation.

Scholars, like Blum, have looked to sailor′s libraries, reading and writing habits in order to reshape cultural views of the sailor, adding new layers to his character that demonstrate his erudition and creativity. *The View from the Masthead* draws attention to "sailors′ literary culture" and looks to sailing men as "important figures in the nineteenth-century American literary public sphere, although their contributions have been little recognized in literary history".[62] Daniel Vickers and Vince Walsh leverage parish records, ships′ musters, and other cultural artifacts in order to build a history of seamen in early America, venturing in *Young Men and the Sea* that to follow the life of the sailor was less about adventure and more about everyday life.[63] Scholars are also beginning to invite intersectional thinking in building the history of the sailor like Jeffrey Bolster′s *Black Jacks* or Michael Jarvis′s *In the Eye of All Trade*.[64] Marcus Rediker′s *Between the Devil and the Deep Blue Sea* scoured archival material in order to build a history of the common sailor as it had never been attempted before, but the work of Isaac Land has extended that research, critiquing some of Rediker′s earlier observations of maritime history, demonstrating how much work is still left to be done in tracking the lives of sailors in the early modern period. Land importantly notes that "The battle over which sailors were authentic, and which were somehow not the real thing, is with us still" and proves that scholars are still in the process of shaping the portrait of the sailor from the Age of Sail.[65] James Davey, in "Singing for the Nation", has looked to eighteenth-century Naval ballads and contends that they "made an important contribution to the broader discourse about the navy and naval recruitment".[66] Too, they shaped the ways in which the Navy was viewed and received during the period when naval impressment was at its height, often drawing attention to the "concerns of seamen" where impressment was concerned.[67] Tied to ballad singing, Elin Jones provides a fascinating discussion concerning sonic protest on naval vessels and how such sounds demonstrated "that seamen understood the power of their collective voices, as well as comprehending the acousmatic potential of the ship in orchestrating their dissent".[68] Historians are also thinking through interdisciplinary lenses and adding levels of creativity to maritime history, like Greg Dening in *Mr Bligh's Bad Language,* which considers the mutiny on the *Bounty* through linguistics and even performance studies, recognising what Edward′s

[61]It is not possible to cover all of the research dealing with Naval surgeon′s logs; however, the work of Seth LeJacq and B. R. Burg each represent the rich contribution naval surgeon′s logs can have to maritime history and, specifically, to the history of gender and sexuality at sea. See LeJacq," 'O My Poor Arse, My Arse Can Best Tell'"8; Burg′s monograph *Boys at Sea* demonstrates that the ship′s surgeon was often called in as a witness in Naval Courts Martial cases for sodomy.
[62]Blum, *The View from the Masthead*, 2.
[63]See Vickers and Walsh, *Young Men and the Sea*.
[64]Bolster, *Black Jacks*; Jarvis, *In the Eye of All Trade*.
[65]Land, *War, Nationalism, and the British Sailor*, 26. For his critique of Rediker, see page 18.
[66]Davey, "Singing for the Nation".
[67]Ibid., 57.
[68]Jones, "Space, Sound and Sedition on the Royal Naval ship, 1756-1815, 72.

notes of sailing life which is that "To be a sailor, I would argue, is to perform" and "A voyage is a performance".[69] The chantey, no doubt, is also a performance intimately tied to expression, knowledge, and to craft, the latter of which is the focus of some discussion in Margaret Cohen's *The Novel and the Sea*.[70]

I take the time to highlight all of these avenues that have been pursued, and the above is in no way exhaustive, as the silence around the sailor's chantey and the dearth of investigative projects begins to seem a gross oversight and a clear missing piece in the reconstruction of the sailor's life before the mast. Unlike other artifacts from the sailing world, in the chantey we are provided with intimate insights into not only potential interiorities of the sailor, but also the collectivity of the forecastle through materials that were shaped by the men, together, as they laboured in the difficult and dangerous work of the sea. The chantey provides what Robert McCarl argues is a part of "occupational folklore", which are folklore objects that scholars should unpack for what they might dispel about "superficial and stereotypical" ideas of the working class, just as Burton has cautioned in her own work concerning the sailor.[71] As a living, breathing, and evolving genre, not unlike what ballad scholars have noted in collected oral traditional materials, chanteys have the potential to inject into maritime discourse an embodied artifact from the sailing man himself, whether from a singular man or from multiple repertoires.[72] Researchers have the opportunity to investigate sailing language and wit, metaphor and mirth, as well as complicated perceptions of identity, the sailing world, and the many people sailors encountered along their expansive routes. Though she is discussing lumberjacks in Ontario, what Edith Fowke notes of researching their songs supports what I see of the untapped potential in collected chantey songs. She writes "Those songs, composed by the men in the camps [she is discussing lumber camps], give a very complete and vivid picture of what it was like to work in the woods in the latter half of the nineteenth century".[73] Similarly, a close reading of collected chantey texts would provide the opportunity to place one's finger on the pulse of maritime life, investigating a cultural artifact from sailing men that was shaped within the confines of their floating, insular, and demanding workspace. Or, at the very least, was shaped as he reflected back on his time at sea.

It is worth providing a few examples of chanteys to demonstrate what these artifacts contain within them, and what communicative power they promise in terms of continued research in the sailor and his life at sea. From the James Madison Carpenter collection, "Leave Her, Johnny, Leave Her", different from the song that opened this article, readers are provided with lamentations from a singing sailor:

Since the day we sailed from Birkenhead,
They whacked us out a pound of bread.
The skipper's name was Bully Brown,
If you looked at him, he would knock you down.
Our work was hard and the voyage was long,

[69]Edwards, "Performing the Sailor," 43 and 45. See Dening, *Mr Bligh's Bad Language*.
[70]Cohen, *The Novel and the Sea*.
[71]McCarl, "Occupational Folklore"; See Burton, " 'Whoring, Drinking Sailors'"; " 'As I wuz a-Rolling Down the Highway One Morn'".
[72]See Mary Ellen Brown, "Placed, Replaced, or Misplaced?: The Ballads' Progress," 121.
[73]Fowke, "Folksong as a Reflection of the Shantyboys' Life".

The seas were high and the gales were strong.
The food was bad and the wages low
But now on shore again we'll go.
The sails are furled; our work is done,
And now on show we'll have our fun[74]

This song contains grievances concerning wages, hard work, poor sustenance, violences perpetrated by the captain of the ship, and a voyage that was long and brought with it incredible natural challenges. The singer expresses both the excitement of leaving the ship and also that the work is coming to a close and "our fun" is on the horizon. Complaints concerning poor food, wages, and treatment were not uncommon in sailing ships and in an entry in his diary, 27 August 1852, Buskirk lamented about the number of weevils extant in his biscuit.[75] In considering Buskirk's journal and the content of "Leave Her, Johnny, Leave Her", scholars might intersect maritime research already completed with collected examples of the chantey tradition in order to generate a synergy between what has been collated and what is yet to be discovered within the many uninvestigated collections of chanteys. An illustrative project might connect sailing memoirs to the content in sailing chanteys to illuminate interior musings of the sailor not captured in other places like the ships' musters or surgeon's logs. Possibly, the sailor may admit more under the cover of song than he would within any other of his cultural artifacts.[76]

Many of the songs contained in archival spaces also speak to the sailors' relationship with sex and sexuality, a key discussion that demands more focused attention. A version of "Away, Rio" from the R. W. Gordon Collection, one of the bawdier of the archival collections, captures a crystallized representation of sexuality. Collected in 1925 from the informant John R. Spears, he notes that "the men sang 'Away Rio' over and over again —no other song of any kind", demonstrating just how popular tunes like this one were among sailing men despite alternative arguments that the coarseness of chanteys has been overstated.[77] The version provided by Spears reads:

Oh where are you going to my pretty maid?
Away Riot [*sic*]
Oh where are you going to my pretty maid?
And we're bound to Rio Grande.
"I'm going out milking, sor," she said.
May I go with you my pretty maid?
"Oh, yes, if you please, kind sor," she said.
Well then will you diddle me, my pretty maid?
"Oh, yes, if you please, kind sir," she said.

In this short example, the reader encounters the figure of the singing sailor, the "pretty maid", and her vocation of milking. The song contains a pointed reference to sex where the singer requests "will you diddle me" and scholars of the eighteenth century would

[74]Carpenter, James Madison Carpenter Collection, (Carpenter notes that the original source was not recorded: number 397).
[75]Philip C. Van Buskirk, The Journals of Philip C. Van Buskirk, 1852, Digitized as a part of CUNY Academic Commons, https://vanbuskirk.commons.gc.cuny.edu/the-diary-of-philip-c-van-buskirk/
[76]See Scott, *Domination and the Arts of Resistance* .
[77]See Terry, *The Way of the Ship*, where he notes "We hear a great deal of the coarseness and even lewdness of the shanty, but I could wish a little more stress were laid on the sailor's natural delicacy" (10).

recognise the erotic suggestion of the milkmaid character. Milking and milkmaids gesture at both the vocation of milking cows, but they also conjure images of fellatio, fecundity, and masturbation.[78] This song should be compared alongside of other milkmaid songs that arrive in archival collections of chanteys and that Hugill notes in his discussion of versions of "Blow the Man Down".[79] Here, songs provide a window into the ways in which sailors may have viewed themselves, their erotic partners, and even the sexual outlets available to them. Lyrics likely provided space for men to collectively share in the scopophilic consumption of women's bodies and erotic material while also functioning to solidify masculine bonds necessary for the successful navigation and functioning of the sailing ship. Cathy Lynn Preston demonstrates that "Sharing a bawdy song is analogous to sharing a female body, a kind of 'group bang', if you will".[80] Songs like "Away Rio", among so many others, are key artifacts through which to consider the ways ideas about sexuality become cemented in the space of song and poetry, but they also serve as a means to illustrate social bonding, sexual release, and even vulnerable moments of expressed longing as they are focused on erotic objects and fetishised bodies.

There is also more to be done with looking at chantey narratives for how they communicate a recognition of gender and sexual fluidity. As Blum has noted of Herman Melville's work

> The liquidity of the medium [here, she is discussing *Moby Dick* and the oceanic novel] in fact bears a conceptual or theoretical charge, as the novel's vision of the crew members 'squeezing [them]selves into each other' imagines oceanic forms of relation that burst the boundaries and fixed terms of land-based, heterosexual expectations encoded in the stable, rigid categories such as 'the wife' or 'the bed, the table, the saddle,'—which Ishmael will come to find stifling and inadequate.[81]

For me, the chantey holds the same potential of *bursting boundaries* and troubling *stable, rigid categories* of what we know about the sailor and his life, evidenced in songs like "the false parts motif" version of "Blow the Man Down". The song begins much like other versions of "Blow the Man Down", complete with references to milking and sexuality; however, by the time the sailor and the maid make it to the lodgings of the prostitute, a transformation occurs which presents opportunities for readings akin to what Blum highlights about Melville and other oceanic texts. The final stanzas of the song read:

> Her catheads came off when she took off her dress
> Also with her bonnet came off her bright tress.
> Then she unscrewed her left leg-unhooked her right ear
> By that time believe me, I was feelin' dam queer.
> When she spat out her teeth, and gouged out her right eye,
> I grabbed up my dunnage, and left her to die.
> Take warnin' my hearties, when you go ashore

[78]See Floyd, "Engaging Imperfect Texts".
[79]Hugill claims that there are six major versions of the song in *Shanties from the Seven Seas*, 157. Frederick Pease Harlow, in his *Chanteying Aboard American Ships*, (Connecticut: Mystic Seaport, 2004) claims that the song has been sung so much that "the words are legion." 92.
[80]Preston, "'The Tying of the Garter'".
[81]Blum, "Introduction; Oceanic Studies," 153. For discussion concerning chanteys in Herman Melville's work, see Frank's, " 'Cheer'ly Man'"

Steer clear of false riggins & moor to a whore.[82]

The use of the term *queer*, in the song, likely attaches to the feeling of queerness or feeling "Out of sorts; unwell; faint, giddy".[83] Potentially, it also refers to a feeling or a person seeming "Strange, odd, peculiar, eccentric"; however, the queer nature of the song is not only within the arguable sensations of the characters but also within the movements of the female figure as she transforms before the eyes of the singer.[84] In her transition, scholars are able to engage queer readings of the text to illuminate fascinating articulations of gender, sexuality, and identity. Like the queer undercurrents of *Moby Dick*, and other Melville novels, chanteys like "Blow the Man Down" contain lyrical sites where traditional and rigid categories of gender and sexuality are troubled and negotiated, leaving room to imagine a strictly maritime conception of such categories which often appear far more kaleidoscopic and even fluid, not unlike the waters sailors navigated.[85] Centreing a queer reading of chanteys, as I produce in my investigation of the unpublished unexpurgated repertoire of Hugill in my *Cabin Boys, Milkmaids, and Rough Seas*, contributes a further level of nuance to maritime history.[86]

Chanteys communicate the situation of the sailor and also contain within them a snapshot of a particular world view and even a conception of self and other that functioned to make meaning in spaces that might make someone feel powerless or even insignificant. More than anything else, though, is that researching collected chantey texts succeeds in leveraging voices from the forecastle, and from working-class spaces more generally, viewing these materials in the same way as other cultural objects that have already enjoyed wide scholarly attention. In fact, as Rediker argues of history more generally: "history, in my view, [is] seen from the wrong end of the spyglass".[87] Researching sailing artifacts, like the chantey, permits space for scholars to consider history from the perspectives of those who lived their lives on and attached to the sea. Bullen argues of chanteys "Poor doggerel they were mostly and often very lewd and filthy, but they gave the knowing and appreciative shipmates, who roared the refrain, much opportunity for laughter", and I would add that they also contain within them delicate and often kaleidoscopic articulations of identity, experience, and perspective of the world.[88] They are, too, registers of longing, desire, frustration, exploration, and even agency. As simple as many of the songs are, the weight of what is articulated resounds and the reward of concerted attention to these artifacts of the sea is understanding and visiting yet another layer of human experience and doing so through a prized tool of sailing work.

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[82]Robert Winslow Gordon, Inferno Collection, 1917-1929, https://archive.org/details/1917gordoninfernocollection/page/n87/mode/2up

[83]*Oxford English Dictionary*, "*queer (adj. 1),* sense 2," June 2025, https://doi.org/10.1093/OED/8881413027.

[84]Oxford English Dictionary, "queer (adj.1), sense 1.a," June 2025, https://doi.org/10.1093/OED/1082843456.

[85]For an example of training a queer theoretical lens on historical or literary content see Ftacek, "Jonathan Swift and the Transgender Classroom" for an example of using a proto-trans lens to investigate monstrosity in Swift's "The Lady's Dressing Room," a poem quite similar to this song.

[86]Floyd, *Cabin Boys, Milkmaids, and Rough Seas*.

[87]Rediker, *Outlaws of the Atlantic*, 177.

[88]Bullen, *Songs of Sea Labor*, vi.

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